

Week 7: Setting in Biblical Narrative

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

Where and when a Bible story happens is rarely just backdrop — tonight we'll look at how setting does its own kind of work.

1. Think of a movie or show where the setting alone told you what kind of story you were about to watch — a dark old house, a courtroom, a small town. What settings instantly set your expectations like that?
2. **Read Genesis 3:23-24, Genesis 4:16, and Genesis 11:1-2.** Which direction is each person or group heading? What has just happened in each story at the moment they go that way? Then read **2 Chronicles 36:15-20** — where does the whole nation eventually end up? Once a narrator has done this a few times, what does the mere mention of someone moving "east" set you up to expect?
3. **Read Genesis 7:12.** How long do the rains last? Now skim two other "forties": Moses on the mountain while the people wait below (**Exodus 24:18; 32:1**), and the spies' report and what follows (**Numbers 13:25; 14:33-34**). What kind of situation does "forty" keep marking? How do people tend to do during it?
4. **Read Matthew 4:1-11.** Jesus gets the same forty-day setup, in the same wilderness. How do his forty days go differently from Israel's? Why might a Gospel writer want that echo right at the start of Jesus' ministry?
5. **Read Matthew 2:13-23.** In the Old Testament, Egypt is the place of bondage: Abraham's family first goes down there to escape a famine, their descendants end up enslaved for generations, and even after the exodus the law warns Israel never to go back (Deuteronomy 17:16). "Down to Egypt" is a move you've learned to read as trouble. Yet when Jesus' family flees Herod, Egypt becomes the place of safety instead. Why would an author deliberately flip a setting on us like this?
6. **Read Genesis 19:30-38, then Numbers 25:1-3, then Deuteronomy 23:3.** By the time you've read those three, what does the name "Moab" make you brace for? Now read **Ruth 1:1-5** — a family from Bethlehem moves to Moab, and the sons marry Moabite women. What do you expect this to lead to?

7. **Read Ruth 4:13-17.** Whose great-grandmother does Ruth the Moabite turn out to be? What is the author doing by placing the origin of that line in Moab, of all places — the setting the story has trained us to dread? How is this the same move Matthew makes with Egypt?
8. Is there a "setting" in your own life right now — a season, a place, a kind of waiting — that feels like your own wilderness or your own "forty days"? What do you think might be going on in that timing?
9. As we close, what's one place or time-marker in Scripture that you now want to pay closer attention to the next time you come across it?